



team gelled well. We were taught about teamwork and discipline. Even though we did not have any match practice ahead of the Games, we did have a national camp in Bengaluru, where we had a session with field marshal Sam Manekshaw. It was an incredible experience.

Initially, we could not even believe that the Sam Manekshaw was amongst us to talk about hockey. He stressed on discipline. I also remember how a few senior players were not allowed in the camp as they did not come in time, so that was the level of discipline and strictness we had. Everyone was serious about the team and Manekshaw's visit made us proud that a man of his stature took time out to address us.

People often ask me how we handled pressure and, to be honest, when you are young, you do not think about all those factors. You just train well and want to give your best

and Baskaran advised us to play our natural game. That helped us handle diverse situations.

The only time the pressure got to me was on the eve of the final. I had a sleepless night and just thought about the fact that we will make history if we bagged that coveted gold medal, after 16 years. In a team meeting that followed, Baskaran and our coach cooled our nerves and motivated us to play to our potential.

I remember seniors like Bir Bahadur Chhetri told us to treat the final like any other game. Since we had performed well against Spain and the USSR previously, in the early games we just needed to ride on the momentum. Most importantly, we had some really good and talented players in all the positions who stepped up when it mattered the most.

It has been 44 years since that iconic victory, but every time I

remember those days, it makes me emotional. As the national anthem played and we were handed the gold medals, I could remember the struggles my father had to face to make me a hockey player. He, too, wanted to play the game but couldn't, so he left no stone unturned to help me fulfill my dreams.

Back then, we would stay in Ambarnath, about 50 kms from Mumbai, but he always took me to watch international hockey fixtures and helped me realise my dream.

I also can't thank my school enough because, without their support, a 21-year-old wouldn't have been able to be part of history.

With the gold hanging around our neck, our eyes were moist. Those were the tears of joy and that medal was a recognition of our dedication and hard work!

As told to Shayan Acharya